MARCH 15–21, 2026 · ISSUE #1 · SUNDAY EDITION

The Signal.

Every system is running at capacity — diplomatic, military, economic, cognitive. The things falling through the cracks are as important as the headlines.

IRAN WAR | CENTRAL BANKS | UKRAINE | SWITCH 2 | CHAMPIONS LEAGUE | PROJECT HAIL MARY | STAR WARS | MALAZAN | CARPENTER BRUT | IDES OF MARCH

WHAT'S INSIDE

WORLD

Iran War Week Three — Bandwidth Is the Story

Kharg Island burns, Gulf states intercept hundreds of missiles, and every other crisis on Earth loses its place in the queue.

WORLD

Central Banks Freeze — Stagflation Returns

Four central banks hold in a single day. The easing cycle is dead. The BoE's unanimous vote says more than any press conference.

WORLD

Pakistan–Afghanistan — The War Nobody Covered

An alleged hospital strike killed 408 people. It barely made the news. Two Muslim-majority states at war in Iran's shadow.

GAMING

Crimson Desert Sells 2M in 24 Hours

Pearl Abyss's open-world RPG is the breakout hit of early 2026 — and it's available on GeForce NOW.

LEGO

LEGO Star Wars Smart Play Launches

Eight sets, three Smart Bricks, and a companion app. The biggest shift in LEGO play since Mindstorms.

FOOTBALL

Arsenal's Title — Is This the Year?

Nine points clear. Seven games left. The club that hasn't won the league since 2004 can finally taste it.

FOOTBALL

CL Quarter-Final Draw — The Strongest in Years

Real Madrid vs Bayern. Barça vs Atleti. PSG vs Liverpool. Sporting vs Arsenal. No easy ties. No filler.

FILM

Project Hail Mary Opens — Hard Sci-Fi Goes Big

Gosling alone in space, Lord & Miller directing, and early word is exceptional. The Interstellar of 2026.

STAR WARS

Maul Shadow Lord Trailer Drops

Watercolour noir animation, Sam Witwer's physical performance capture, and a tone unlike anything in the franchise before.

BOOKS

Nebula Finalists + Malazan Endgame Confirmed

Erikson says Walk in Shadow is nearly done. After that: both authors are leaving the Malazan world.

MUSIC

Carpenter Brut Closes the Leather Trilogy

Leather Temple lands. Eight years, three albums, one story about nuclear ruin and neon cities. The darkwave event of the year.

FITNESS

Dan John's 2-Day Kettlebell Programme

Focus and practice. Two days, six movements, sixty-second rests. Simple, durable, applicable at any level.

HISTORY

The Ides of March — 2,080 Years Later

A conspiracy designed to save a republic that instead ended it. The gap between what we intend and what we cause.

Bandwidth is finite. That is the thread running through everything this week — from Washington's diplomatic switchboard, overwhelmed by Iran and deaf to Ukraine, to the Bank of England's nine-to-zero paralysis, to 92 million Iranians cut from the internet at one percent of capacity. When every channel is saturated, the signal that gets through is the loudest, not the most important. The things that dropped out of the queue this week — a hospital strike that killed 408

people, a record day of Russian casualties, a planet made of magma — deserved better than silence.

THE LONG SHELF — WORTH YOUR TIME

Phil Lord & Christopher Miller on Project Hail Mary

Rolling Stone · Interview

The directors of Into the Spider-Verse explain how they turned Andy Weir's novel into a two-and-a-half-hour love letter to scientific curiosity — and why practical sets beat CGI for an astronaut alone in space.

Cillian Murphy on Tommy Shelby, Shyness, and Winning an Oscar

CBS Sunday Morning · 14-minute extended interview

A rare unguarded conversation with an actor who admits he's "quite a shy person." On getting back into the razor-blade cap, on chasing great writing since he was twenty, and on whether an Oscar adds or removes pressure.

JWST Reveals a New Class of Molten Planet

University of Oxford · Research announcement

Thirty-five light-years away, a super-Earth has been permanently molten for five billion years. Oxford researchers say it's the first confirmed member of an entirely new category of world. JWST continues to shatter paradigms.

Pavel Tsatsouline on Huberman Lab — Strength as Skill

Podcast Notes · Summary of Huberman Lab episode

The core thesis: strength is neurological, not muscular. Greasing the Groove, wave progression, never training to failure. Soviet-era principles for lifelong training. Essential if you own a kettlebell.

Adam Savage Tours the Hail Mary Spacecraft Set

Tested / YouTube · 25 minutes

Production Designer Charlie Wood walks Savage through the fully built practical interior of the Hail Mary — a set designed to solve unique problems of zero-gravity staging. Genuinely fascinating for anyone who cares about how films are made.

Five Extra Minutes of Sleep, Two Minutes of Exercise, Half a Vegetable

Scientific American · Health research

A University of Sydney study tracking 60,000 people finds that the smallest possible improvements to sleep, exercise, and diet — when combined — add a full year of life. The synergy is the story.

Inside Maul Shadow Lord's Animation

Star Wars News Net · Deep dive

Sam Witwer shot live-action reference footage, with animation directly modelled on his performance. A watercolour-and-paint-on-glass aesthetic unlike anything Lucasfilm has attempted before. How they did it.

Iran's 92 Million People, Cut Off

New York Times · Long read

Internet connectivity at one percent for three weeks. Starlink dishes confiscated door-to-door. A blueprint for digital despotism being built in real time with Chinese hardware. The future of authoritarian internet control.

THE WORLD THIS WEEK

Iran Week Three: When Every System Runs at Capacity

~$90	$10B+	1%	9-0
BRENT $/BARREL	US WAR COST (2 WKS)	IRAN INTERNET	BOE HOLD VOTE

By Sunday March 15, the US-Israeli campaign against Iran was into day sixteen. The operational picture had shifted: after the opening phase of leadership decapitation — Supreme Leader Khamenei killed in the initial strikes, former president Ahmadinejad initially reported dead but later found alive — the US moved to targeting Iran's economic chokepoints. On Friday March 13, President Trump ordered strikes on Kharg Island, the terminal that handles roughly 90% of Iran's crude oil exports. Trump told NBC's Kristen Welker the strikes had "totally demolished" much of the island and warned of more. The Strait of Hormuz — responsible for around 20% of global oil supply — remained under intense pressure.

Iran was not passive. Saudi Arabia intercepted six missiles and 34 drones in a single overnight salvo on March 15. Bahrain has brought down more than 125 missiles and over 200 drones since hostilities began. The UAE suffered a drone strike at Fujairah that disrupted oil-loading operations. Iranian ballistic missiles had already struck Al Udeid Air Base in Qatar — the largest US military base in the region. US forces torpedoed the Iranian frigate IRIS Dena off Sri

Lanka, killing at least 87 of the 180 aboard. The war has cost the United States over $10 billion in its first two weeks, with at least six American soldiers dead.

The real story, beyond the kinetic theatre, is the diplomatic geometry. Russia is providing Iran with intelligence to help target US ships and assets — turning this from a bilateral affair into a test of great-power alignment. China is in talks with Iran over safe passage for tankers through Hormuz. The EU's Costa and von der Leyen are video-conferencing Gulf leaders. US Treasury Secretary Bessent was in Paris preparing for a potential Trump-Xi summit. And at the UN Security Council, the US and allies clashed with Russia and China over Iran's nuclear programme — confirming that even the shared architecture of non-proliferation governance has fractured.

> THE ANGLE
>
> This is no longer a war about Iran's nuclear programme. It is the first open test, since the Cold War, of whether the US can fight a major regional conflict while the Russia-China axis actively assists the other side. Every meeting, every ceasefire feeler, every IAEA inspection clause now happens in that shadow.

Democracy Now · ACLED · ISW · NCRI

Central Banks Freeze: The Day Four Economies Said "We Don't Know"

Thursday March 19 produced one of the most extraordinary single days in recent central banking history. The Bank of England voted 9-0 to hold at 3.75% — the first unanimous decision since September 2021. Markets had priced in a 7-2 split expecting two members to push for cuts. The BoE now warns CPI could hit 3.5% by Q3, up from 2.1% just weeks earlier, entirely driven by the Iran-war energy shock. Two-year gilt yields spiked 33 basis points to 4.43%. Market pricing shifted: from two cuts expected this year to two potential hikes.

The ECB held at 2.00%, raised its 2026 inflation forecast to 2.6%, and cut growth to 0.9%. The Bank of Japan held at 0.75%. The Federal Reserve had held the previous day. S&P Global cut 2026 growth forecasts "pretty much across the board" and raised inflation projections. US new home sales collapsed 17.6% to 587,000 annualised — the lowest since October 2022.

> THE ANGLE
>
> This is stagflation through the mechanism of a single conflict. Policymakers who spent 2024 celebrating their navigation of post-pandemic inflation are watching energy prices

tear through their models again — not from a supply shock they can dismiss as "transitory," but from a war their governments are either participating in or being pressured to join. The BoE's unanimous hold is the political signal as much as the monetary one.

Rio Times · S&P Global · Fitch Ratings

DID YOU KNOW?

The Strait of Hormuz is just 33 kilometres wide at its narrowest point. Through it flows roughly one-fifth of the world's entire oil supply — about 21 million barrels per day. There is no alternative route for most Gulf oil exports.

Ukraine: The War Washington Forgot

Ukrainian forces eliminated 1,710 Russian soldiers in a single day this week — the highest single-day casualty figure in 2026. Drone operators alone accounted for approximately 900 kills in a 36-hour window. Russia has lost close to 100,000 soldiers in the first three months of 2026, with Zelensky claiming 90% of those casualties were caused by drones. And yet: the Kremlin announced a pause in peace negotiations — coinciding precisely with the moment Trump's bandwidth became consumed by the Iran war. Russia plans to recruit an additional 400,000 soldiers in 2026. Washington postponed the latest settlement talks.

The record daily losses and Ukraine's effective removal from Washington's diplomatic agenda are two sides of the same coin. Russia is simultaneously taking catastrophic casualties and being handed a strategic gift: no pressure to negotiate.

UATV English · ISW

Pakistan–Afghanistan: 408 Dead, and Nobody Looked Up

Since late February, Pakistan and Afghanistan have been in open military conflict. This week's pivotal moment: Afghan officials alleged that a Pakistani airstrike hit the Omid Addiction Treatment Hospital in Kabul on Monday March 16, killing at least 408 people and wounding 265 others — the deadliest single attack since the conflict's escalation. Pakistan denied the claim, saying it targeted an ammunition depot. The UN's OHCHR had already confirmed 289 Afghan civilians, including 104 children and 59 women, killed or injured before the hospital figures were added. On Wednesday, Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Qatar brokered a temporary ceasefire for Eid al-Fitr.

Two Muslim-majority states at war over the consequences of a twenty-year Western project, playing out in near-total Western media silence. The hospital strike allegation — 408 people killed in a single building — would have been the defining news event of any ordinary week. It barely registered.

Time · Al Jazeera · Washington Post

Northern Ireland: £35 Per Household

Two-thirds of NI households depend on home heating oil — a commodity with no price regulation and no equivalent to the energy price cap that protects gas and electricity customers in Great Britain. Within a single week in early March, the average cost of 500 litres jumped from £307 to £556 — an 81% increase. On Monday, the UK government announced £17 million for Northern Ireland from a £53 million UK-wide support package. With roughly 500,000 oil-heating homes, the allocation works out to about £35 per household. First Minister Michelle O'Neill called it a "slap in the face." The same week, the Independent Remuneration Board confirmed a 27% pay rise for Stormont MLAs — from £53,000 to £67,200.

BBC News · NI Dept of Finance · ITV UTV

ALSO THIS WEEK

Iran internet blackout enters week three — connectivity at 1% of normal for 92 million people. The government is building a permanent "Barracks Internet" modelled on North Korea, using Huawei and Chinese infrastructure. Starlink dishes are being confiscated door-to-door.

Starmer's tightrope — the PM says Britain won't be "drawn into a wider war" but has deployed Typhoons to Qatar and Cyprus and confirmed intelligence sharing "around the clock." The distinction between defensive and offensive is increasingly incoherent. Reuters

Gerry Adams lawsuit struck out — three men withdrew their London High Court civil case over IRA bombings. Justice Craven found it crossed the threshold for abuse of process. Reuters

Kent meningitis outbreak — an "unprecedented" MenB cluster linked to a Canterbury nightclub has killed two, infected 20+. Public health officials are investigating whether shared vapes may have been the transmission vector. BBC News

Artemis II reaches the launch pad — NASA's SLS rocket rolled out to Pad 39B on Friday. First launch window: April 1. If it flies, it will be the first crewed mission beyond low Earth orbit since Apollo 17 in December 1972 — a 53-year gap. NASA

JWST discovers an entirely new class of planet — a super-Earth 35 light-years away that has been permanently molten for five billion years, with a self-sustaining sulphur atmosphere cycle. Oxford · Nature Astronomy

PIXEL & BYTE

Crimson Desert Sells Two Million Copies in 24 Hours

Crimson Desert from Pearl Abyss — the studio behind Black Desert Online — launched on March 19 and immediately became the breakout title of early 2026. A standalone single-player open-world action RPG set in the war-torn fantasy world of Pywel, it sold two million copies in its first 24 hours across PC, PS5, Xbox, and Mac. At $69.99 ($61.19 on Steam), it's the big single-player game of March — and it's available on GeForce NOW, meaning you can stream it on a Steam Deck or Xiaomi Pad at ultra settings without the local hardware.

Wikipedia · NVIDIA Blog

Switch 2: Mario Wonder Gets Bellabel Park

Super Mario Bros. Wonder — Switch 2 Edition + Meetup in Bellabel Park launches March 26 with new co-op content exclusive to Switch 2. Local and online multiplayer challenges in a new area. Nintendo is demoing it at PAX East alongside *Pokémon Pokopia*. For a family with a 10-year-old, the co-op angle is genuinely compelling.

Nintendo Official

GPT-5.4 Mini Goes Free; Gemini 3.1 Doubles Benchmarks

OpenAI rolled out GPT-5.4 mini to free ChatGPT users via the "Thinking" feature — reasoning-capable AI, previously behind paywalls, now accessible to everyone. Google's Gemini 3.1 Pro scored 77.1% on ARC-AGI-2 reasoning benchmarks — roughly double its predecessor. The model picker simplified to three tiers: Instant, Thinking, Pro.

OpenAI · Gemini

LEGO Star Wars Smart Play: The Biggest Shift in Play Since Mindstorms

LEGO launched its Smart Play interactive building system this month, debuting with eight Star Wars sets. Smart Bricks connect to a companion app and respond to Smart Minifigures and Smart Tags with sounds and interactions. The catch: only three of the eight sets include a Smart Brick — the TIE Advanced ($69.99), Red Five X-Wing ($89.99), and Throne Room Duel ($159.99). The other five require one of those three to activate the interactive features. For a family with a 10-year-old into Star Wars LEGO, the TIE Advanced is the cheapest entry point.

Also new this month: the LEGO *Zelda: Ocarina of Time — The Final Battle* set ($129.99) — only the second Zelda set ever made. The original Great Deku Tree retires by end of 2026, so if you want

both, prioritise that one now.

Jay's Brick Blog · Stonewars

DID YOU KNOW?

LEGO also released an *Icons: Project Hail Mary* set this month ($99.99) — timed to the film. A LEGO spaceship based on Andy Weir's novel, sitting on the shelf next to the Sauron's Helmet. Two very different kinds of solitary journeys.

Pixel Bug Warning: Hold Off on the March Update

Multiple Pixel 10, Pixel 10 Pro, Pixel 9a, and Pixel 8 Pro users are reporting phones freezing on the always-on display and lock screen after installing the March 2026 Pixel Drop. The March drop does include useful features — Circle to Search upgrades, Gemini agent actions, a standalone Now Playing app — but the freeze bug is widespread enough to justify waiting a week for a patch.

PhoneArena · Google Blog

ALSO IN TECH & GAMING

Death Stranding 2: On the Beach arrived on PC (March 19). Kojima's meditative traversal sequel with PC-exclusive graphical features. GameSpot

Kena: Bridge of Spirits comes to Switch 2 (March 26) with Anniversary DLC and New Game+. A gorgeous action-adventure previously exclusive to PlayStation and PC. Gamereactor

System Shock Remake gets a major performance boost — 1440p/60fps docked on Switch 2 plus Joy-Con 2 mouse support. DLH.net

007 First Light — a new James Bond game launches March 27 on all platforms including Switch 2. Built on the Glacier Engine (Hitman). GDC Showcase

Slay the Spire 2 entered Early Access with co-op multiplayer for up to four players — a feature the beloved original never had. GeForce NOW

Steam Machine still coming in 2026 — Valve reaffirmed its living-room console, Steam Frame VR headset, and new controller are on track. TechRadar

Android 16 QPR3 security update fixes 129 vulnerabilities including an actively exploited zero-day in Media Codecs (remote code execution). Install it — but watch the Pixel freeze bug. Gadget Hacks

LEGO retirement alert — Willy Wonka set ($219.99), Italian Riviera ($299.99), Gizmo ($109.99), Fountain Garden ($89.99), and several Animal Crossing sets all retire July 31. Brick Fanatics

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE — R16 SECOND LEG RESULTS (MAR 17–18)

Chelsea 0–3 PSG
Agg: 2-8 · PSG ✓

Sporting 5–0 Bodø/Glimt (aet)
Agg: 5-3 · Sporting ✓

Arsenal 2–0 Leverkusen
Agg: 3-1 · Arsenal ✓

Real Madrid 2–1 Man City
Agg: 5-1 · Real Madrid ✓

Liverpool 4–0 Galatasaray
Agg: 4-1 · Liverpool ✓

Barcelona 7–2 Newcastle
Agg: 8-3 · Barcelona ✓

Bayern 4–1 Atalanta
Agg: 10-2 · Bayern ✓

Atlético vs Tottenham
Agg: 7-5 · Atlético ✓

QUARTER-FINAL DRAW

PSG vs **Liverpool**

Real Madrid vs **Bayern Munich**

Barcelona vs **Atlético Madrid**

Sporting CP vs **Arsenal**

First legs April 7–8. Second legs April 14–15. Final: May 30, Puskás Aréna, Budapest. The semi-final path: PSG/Liverpool vs Real Madrid/Bayern, and Barcelona/Atleti vs Sporting/Arsenal.

UEFA

THE ANGLE

This is the strongest Champions League quarter-final set in years. No Lille, no Atalanta, no plucky mid-tier survivor to ease anyone's path. Real Madrid vs Bayern is a final in itself. Barcelona vs Atlético is a Madrid derby with continental stakes. A PSG vs Arsenal final is not inconceivable — and would be irresistible. Chelsea's 8–2 aggregate humiliation against PSG is its own story: whoever replaced Enzo Maresca has a lot of work to do.

SERIE A — TOP 6 (AFTER MATCHDAY 29)

#	TEAM	P	W	D	L	GD	PTS
1	Inter Milan	29	22	2	5	+42	68
2	Napoli	30	19	5	6	+16	62
3	AC Milan	29	17	9	3	+23	60
4	Como	29	15	9	5	+26	54

5	**Juventus**	**29**	**15**	**8**	**6**	**+23**	**53**
6	AS Roma	29	16	3	10	+16	51

PREMIER LEAGUE — TOP 6 (AFTER MATCHDAY 31)

#	TEAM	P	W	D	L	GD	PTS
1	**Arsenal**	**31**	**21**	**7**	**3**	**+39**	**70**
2	Man City	30	18	7	5	+32	61
3	Man United	31	15	10	6	+13	55
4	Aston Villa	30	15	6	9	+3	51
5	Liverpool	30	14	7	9	+9	49
6	Chelsea	30	13	9	8	+18	48

Arsenal and the Title They Finally Deserve

Arsenal lead by nine points. Their 2-0 win over Everton on March 14 was followed by City dropping points for the second consecutive match — 1-1 at West Ham — and the gap went from seven to nine. NBC Sports called it "the night Arsenal won the Premier League" — bold, but not unreasonable. With seven matches remaining and an April 19 showdown at the Etihad still to come, it isn't mathematically over, but Arsenal's squad depth, form, and mental resilience suggest this is theirs to lose. They haven't won a league title since 2004. Mikel Arteta, who has had his patience tested across multiple near-misses, deserves enormous credit.

Juve: Two Clean Sheets and a Midfield Problem

Juventus ground out a narrow 1-0 win at Udinese — Jérémie Boga's third consecutive Serie A goal — making it two wins and two clean sheets in their last two. After the Champions League exit to Galatasaray (7-5 on aggregate, a second-leg comeback that fell agonisingly short in extra time), back-to-back league wins matter. Tonight they host Sassuolo. Three points would take them to 56, within range of fourth-placed Como on 54. Kenan Yıldız has 9 goals and 6 assists this season — the first Juventus player since the league expanded to 20 teams to register 15+ goal contributions before turning 21. Vlahović is doubtful with a tendon issue; Jonathan David starts.

Spalletti wants a midfielder (Ederson from Atalanta, €35-40m), a striker, and potentially a free-transfer marquee name — Bernardo Silva from City is on the radar. A squad overhaul of four to

five players is planned for the summer.

> THE TAKE
>
> Juventus's structural problem is not the manager — it's the midfield. Spalletti has been handed a squad whose creative axis is energetic but not commanding. None of Koopmeiners, McKennie, or Thuram dictates play the way Brozović or Jorginho did at their best. Until they sign someone who can genuinely run the show, Juve will keep winning scrappy 1-0s when on form and shipping 3-3s against mid-table Roma when they're not. The Yıldız renaissance is real, but you cannot build a title-challenging midfield around Weston McKennie.

💡

DID YOU KNOW?

Como — fourth in Serie A with Cesc Fàbregas as manager — have become the story of the Italian season. Tasos Douvikas became the first foreign player in Como's history, and the first Greek, to score ten Serie A goals in a single season. The late-table collapse everyone predicted hasn't materialised.

ALSO ON THE PITCH

Tottenham Hotspur sit 16th with 30 points, three above the drop zone. Thomas Frank was sacked in February; no permanent manager yet. Spurs in a relegation fight is the most surreal subplot in English football.

Man United third under Michael Carrick — three straight league wins including a 3-1 over Villa. The Bournemouth 2-2 draw (Maguire red card) was a setback, not a disaster. Nobody expected United to be here.

Italy's World Cup crisis — two defeats against Norway in qualifying mean a playoff semifinal against Northern Ireland awaits. Inter's double loss to Bodø/Glimt in the CL was the context for the national soul-searching. Reuters

The Players Championship — Cameron Young won at TPC Sawgrass (-13), hitting a 375-yard drive on the 72nd hole — the longest ever recorded on the 18th since ShotLink began. Fitzpatrick (-12) second. Rory T46. PGA Tour

SCREEN & SOUND

Project Hail Mary Opens — Hard Sci-Fi Goes Big

Ryan Gosling wakes up alone in deep space with no memory and one mission: save Earth. Phil Lord and Christopher Miller's adaptation of Andy Weir's beloved 2021 novel opened wide on Thursday in cinemas and IMAX, and early word is exceptional. Sandra Hüller co-stars. At two hours and thirty-six minutes, it's the kind of uncompromising, big-swing hard sci-fi that mainstream cinema rarely attempts — and Lord & Miller, the directors who made *Into the Spider-Verse* and *The LEGO Movie*, turn out to be the perfect choice for material that needs to be simultaneously rigorous and joyful. Rolling Stone's interview with the directors is essential reading; Adam Savage's behind-the-scenes tour of the practical spacecraft set is the companion piece.

Peaky Blinders: The Immortal Man — Tommy Shelby, One Last Time

Peaky Blinders: The Immortal Man landed on Netflix on Thursday — Cillian Murphy back as Tommy Shelby, now at war with his own son, played by Barry Keoghan. Set during World War II, four years after the series ended. Rebecca Ferguson, Tim Roth, and Stephen Graham also return. Created by Steven Knight — who is also writing the next James Bond film. Whether this works as a fitting end to six seasons of razor-blade mythology will be the conversation of the week. Murphy's CBS Sunday Morning interview — on shyness, winning an Oscar, and the discipline of inhabiting Shelby — is the kind of rare, unguarded conversation that makes the film feel earned before you've watched it.

STAR WARS

Maul Shadow Lord: A Trailer That Looks Like Nothing Else in the Franchise

The official trailer for *Star Wars: Maul – Shadow Lord* dropped Monday, confirming its April 6 Disney+ premiere as a two-episode event (final episodes on May 4 — Star Wars Day). Set after *The Clone Wars*, the 10-episode animated series follows Darth Maul rebuilding his criminal empire during the early days of the Galactic Empire. He crosses paths with Devon Izara, a young Jedi Padawan who survived Order 66.

The animation style is the story. A noir-inflected watercolour-and-paint-on-glass aesthetic unlike anything in the franchise — more graphic novel than Saturday morning. Sam Witwer returns as Maul (his voice since *The Clone Wars*), and the production process is closer to motion capture than traditional voice work: Witwer shot full reference footage, with animation directly

modelled on his physical performance. Created by Dave Filoni, developed with Matt Michnovetz, supervising director Brad Rau.

The Mandalorian & Grogu marketing has kicked into gear ahead of the May 22 theatrical release — the first Star Wars film since *The Rise of Skywalker* in 2019. Empire Magazine's May issue features the full team: Favreau, Filoni (now confirmed as Lucasfilm's co-President alongside Lynwen Brennan), Pedro Pascal, Sigourney Weaver, and Jeremy Allen White as Rotta the Hutt. Filoni describes the film as "a big celebration" of Din Djarin and Grogu.

Hypebeast · Jedi News · IGN

THE RELEASE RADAR

NOW SHOWING / JUST DROPPED

20 MAR	**Project Hail Mary** — Gosling alone in space; Lord/Miller adaptation of Weir's novel Cinemas / IMAX
20 MAR	**Peaky Blinders: The Immortal Man** — Tommy Shelby vs his own son in WWII Netflix
21 MAR	**The Bad Guys 2** — DreamWorks heist-comedy sequel Netflix
18 MAR	**Invincible Season 4** — The most brutal superhero animation returns Prime Video
10 MAR	**One Piece Season 2** — Into the Grand Line; all 8 episodes streaming Netflix
20 MAR	**Deadloch Season 2** — Australia's funniest/darkest crime show enters "Tropical Gothic" era Prime Video
20 MAR	**Outlander S8 Ep.3 "Abies Fraseri"** — Final season continues weekly through May 8 Starz
6 MAR	**Hoppers** — Pixar's new original, holding strong at #1 with ~$96M in two weeks Cinemas
RE-REL	**Kiki's Delivery Service** — Ghibli's 1989 masterpiece back on the big screen via GKIDS Cinemas (limited)

COMING SOON

22 MAR	**The Count of Monte Cristo** — Sam Claflin, Jeremy Irons; 8-part Dumas adaptation PBS Masterpiece
22 MAR	**The Comeback Season 3** — Lisa Kudrow's Valerie Cherish returns, starring in an AI-written sitcom HBO
24 MAR	**Daredevil: Born Again S2** — Mayor Fisk vs Matt Murdock; Krysten Ritter returns as Jessica Jones Disney+
25 MAR	**Bait** — Riz Ahmed writes/stars; a struggling actor gets the 007 audition of a lifetime Prime Video
27 MAR	**For All Mankind Season 5** — Alternate-history space drama returns Apple TV+

1 APR	**The Super Mario Galaxy Movie** — Illumination/Nintendo sequel; Yoshi debuts; Brie Larson as Rosalina Cinemas
3 APR	**The Drama** — Zendaya + Robert Pattinson; Ari Aster produces; early viewers calling it "a full-on shock" Cinemas (A24)
6 APR	**Star Wars: Maul – Shadow Lord** — Two-episode premiere; 10 eps; watercolour noir animation Disney+
8 APR	**The Boys, Final Season** — The end of the most anarchic superhero show on TV Prime Video
22 MAY	**The Mandalorian & Grogu** — Star Wars returns to the big screen for the first time since 2019 Cinemas / IMAX

LEAVING SOON

26 MAR	**The Wild Robot** — Leaving Netflix this week. Watch it now. Netflix
31 MAR	**The Hurt Locker** — Last chance this month Netflix
APR	**Community (Seasons 1–6)** — Leaving Netflix globally; will remain on Hulu/Peacock Netflix

ALSO STREAMING THIS MONTH

Netflix	**Anatomy of a Fall** — 2023 Palme d'Or winner, arrives March 23
Netflix	**The Green Knight** — A24's Arthurian masterwork, streaming from March 1
Prime	**Poor Things** — Yorgos Lanthimos's Oscar winner, from March 7
Disney+	**Zootopia 2** — Now streaming from March 11
Disney+	**Ghost Elephants** — Werner Herzog directs a Nat Geo doc about mythical elephants in Angola

💡

DID YOU KNOW?

Rock 'n' Roller Coaster at Walt Disney World's Hollywood Studios closed on March 1 — it's being transformed into *Rock 'n' Roller Coaster Starring The Muppets*, featuring The Electric Mayhem on a VIP road trip through Hollywood. Opening summer 2026. Efteling's Hooghmoed — a new free-fall attraction next to Baron 1898 — opens May 1.

ALSO IN FILM & TV

Scarpetta (Prime Video, from March 11) — Nicole Kidman as Patricia Cornwell's forensic pathologist. Jamie Lee Curtis, Bobby Cannavale. Already generating strong buzz.

Young Sherlock (Prime Video) — Guy Ritchie directs Hero Fiennes Tiffin as 19-year-old Holmes at Oxford. Colin Firth. Based on Andrew Lane's book series.

The Bride! — Jessie Buckley as Frankenstein's bride, Christian Bale. Box office underperforming but the craft looks extraordinary. Box Office Mojo

Disney shareholder meeting — announced *Lilo & Stitch 2* (May 2028), *Incredibles 3* (June 2028), *Toy Story 5* this summer. Disneyland Paris studio park becoming Disney Adventure World with *World of Frozen*.

Efteling Raveleijn closed until November for a complete renovation — new storyline, new raven-flight spinning attraction, expanded themed area. The beloved characters return. Efteling

THE SHELF

Malazan's Endgame Is Confirmed

BOOKS

The End of the World's Longest Fantasy

At the February launch event for *No Life Forsaken* at Munro's Books in Victoria, Steven Erikson confirmed what the Malazan community has been both hoping for and dreading. *Walk in Shadow* — the final book of the Kharkanas Trilogy — is very close to hitting the publisher's desk. *Legacies of Betrayal* (Witness #3) is tentatively dated October 1, 2026 — the book almost entirely focused on marine squads. *Witness #4* is tentatively titled *The Last God*, in which Karsa will appear and a certain question about Kruppe's true nature will be addressed. There is, Erikson mentioned, a non-zero chance Kallor gets his own book — the room apparently erupted.

The headline, though, is final: after the current series finish — Witness, Kharkanas, B&KB, Path to Ascendancy — both Erikson and Esslemont will be done with the Malazan world. Ian Esslemont's fifth Path to Ascendancy book is also nearly ready. The broadest, strangest, most demanding fantasy series of the modern era has a definite, approaching endpoint.

Malazan Empire Forum

Two Grimdark Heavyweights Return on March 24

Daughter of Crows

Mark Lawrence · Academy of Kindness #1 · Ace, March 24

A new series from the author of Prince of Thorns. An assassin academy called the Academy of Kindness, where a hundred girls are sold each year and only three emerge. An elderly female protagonist who sold herself. Lawrence

back in core grimdark mode — high-priority for First Law fans.

No Man's Land

Richard K. Morgan · Del Rey, March 24

The author of Altered Carbon and The Steel Remains returns to fantasy. World War I setting, iron-cold fae, noir-inflected grimdark. Village after village in the British countryside swallowed by a Forest inhabited by an ancient fae race. Exactly the register of The Steel Remains — brutal, intelligent, world-weary.

Book Riot · Reactor

2026 Nebula Award Finalists Announced

The SFWA announced its 61st Annual Nebula finalists on March 15. Best Novel nominees include R.F. Kuang's *Katabasis*, Nnedi Okorafor's *Death of the Author*, and John Wiswell's *Wearing the Lion*. Best Dramatic Presentation includes *Severance* S2, *Murderbot: Season One*, and Vince Gilligan's *Pluribus* — all on Apple TV+. Winners at the Nebula Conference, Chicago, June 6.

SFWA Nebulas · Transfer Orbit

Cosmere Heads to Apple TV+

Multiple sources confirmed this month that Brandon Sanderson's Cosmere universe is heading to Apple TV+, beginning with Mistborn and Stormlight adaptations. Sanderson is writing the Mistborn screenplay himself. His *Hoid's Storybook Collection* crowdfunding campaign raised over $5.7 million in 24 hours against a $1M goal.

IGN

MUSIC

Carpenter Brut Closes the Leather Trilogy

Leather Temple landed on February 27 — the third and final part of the Leather Trilogy that began with *Leather Teeth* in 2018 and continued through *Leather Terror* in 2022. Eight years, three albums, one story about Bret Halford in a nuclear-ruined 2077 ruled by Overlords in neon cities. Early reviews describe "crafty Darkwave/Synth/Industrial/Electro" at its most refined. Carpenter Brut is currently on the HEALTH × Carpenter Brut: The Conflict :: Leather Tour — London's O2 Shepherd's Bush Empire was yesterday.

FM-84 confirmed new music for April 25. The long-awaited *Atlas* vinyl repress shipped in February. This may be the first signal of album two. Also out this week: Ladytron's *Paradises*

(darkwave/electropop), Avalon Emerson's *Written Into Changes* (ambient electronic), and U2's surprise EP *Days of Ash* — five tracks responding to Gaza, Ukraine, and Iran.

Kerrang! · FM-84 Facebook · NPR

PODCASTS

Football Weekly (The Guardian): "Was that the night Arsenal won the Premier League?" Max Rushden, Barry Glendenning, Jonathan Liew. Arsenal's growing lead, City's wobble, KSI's purchase of Dagenham & Redbridge. The running theme: whether Arsenal's "ugly wins" make them champions or set up a catastrophic collapse. YouTube

The Bunker (March 19): "Back the Future? — What is Europe for in the 21st Century?" Guest Roderick Beaton, historian and author of *Europe: A New History*. With war in Ukraine, the US drifting toward adversarial posture, and Putin waiting — the episode asks how Europe was forged and what its future looks like now. Excellent companion to the World section. Podfollow

What Went Wrong (March 16): The latest full episode covers *Seven Samurai* — Akira Kurosawa's 1954 masterpiece. A Kubrickian schedule (over a year to shoot), two months filming in mud, cast suffering roundworm and tuberculosis. How the score was rescued from the wastebasket. How Toshiro Mifune saved the film from self-seriousness. Previous episode: *Forrest Gump*. Apple Podcasts

Audio drama picks: *Wake of Corrosion* (sci-fi horror, #1 on Goodpods' audio drama charts), *Escape Pod* (weekly original sci-fi short fiction edited by John Joseph Adams), and *Janus Descending* (completed limited series — two xenoarchaeologists, ancient alien civilisation, perfect for binging).

ALSO ON THE SHELF

Steel Gods by Richard Swan (Empire of the Wolf #2) lands March 31 — one of the best grimdark/industrial fantasy series of the 2020s. Reactor

The Black Crowes — A Pound of Feathers (March 13) — Metacritic 87. Blues-rock at full power, recorded in Nashville in 10 days. Metacritic

Mitski — Nothing's About to Happen to Me (Feb 27) — Metacritic's top-ranked album of 2026 so far. If you haven't heard it, catch up.

Kindle EPUB downloads — from January 2026, DRM-free Kindle books are downloadable as EPUB. Your books are no longer siloed. The biggest Kindle news in years. Good e-Reader

r/Fantasy Book Bingo 2026 — card submission post went live this week. Time to plan your reading

year.

THE SESSION

Dan John's Simple Two-Day Kettlebell Programme

Dan John posted a new video on March 4 that distils decades of training philosophy into what may be his most practical programming template yet. The structure is a two-day split — one day focused on press/row/ab wheel, the other on RDL/front squat/farmer carry. Both movement categories appear in each session, but one is the "focus" (sets of 15, pushing reps) and the other is "practice" (3×8 with exact 60-second rest periods). The key cue, vintage Dan John: "You're not pushing, you're practicing."

The brilliance is in what it doesn't ask you to do. No complex periodisation. No percentage-based loading. No tracking apps. Two days, six movements, timed rests. The focus/practice split ensures you're always building one quality while maintaining the other. For anyone who owns a kettlebell and wants a programme that could run for months without modification, this is the one.

Dan John YouTube · Dan John University

Zone 2: The Conversation That Won't End

Zone 2 training — 60-70% of max heart rate, conversational pace — remains the dominant methodology in recreational running in 2026. The 80/20 structure (80% easy, 20% hard) is the practitioner default. For a four-run week: two Zone 2 sessions of 45-60 minutes, one quality session (intervals or threshold), and one long run mostly at easy pace. The key mistake is drifting into the "grey zone" — too slow for quality work, too fast for aerobic benefit. The talk test remains the simplest check: can you speak full sentences without gasping?

The current nuance: some exercise scientists are pushing back on Zone 2 as the *only* mechanism. Ross Tucker and Kolie Moore argue that serious athletes programme as much high intensity as they need, then fill with low intensity — the volume of easy work matters more than hitting a precise heart rate zone.

The Runner's Digest · Red Bull / Dearden

Hybrid Training: The Balance Principle

Jake Dearden, HYROX pro (55:44 PB; 2:22 marathon in January 2026), spoke to Red Bull this week about the myth that running and strength training don't coexist. His framework for 4-5 sessions per week: one HYROX-style session, one threshold run (800m repeats), one slow long run, one weights session. The governing rule: reduce gym intensity when running volume rises. Don't chase PRs in both lifts and sprints simultaneously. Maintain strength during run-focused blocks; maintain your endurance base during strength blocks.

💡

DID YOU KNOW?

A University of Sydney study tracking 60,000 people found that adding just five extra minutes of sleep, two minutes of extra vigorous exercise, and half a serving of vegetables per day — when combined — adds a full year of life expectancy. The optimal combination (7-8h sleep, 40+ min exercise/day, high-quality diet) yields up to nine extra years. The synergy between the three is the key finding: diet alone is insufficient; sleep alone requires 60% more per night to match the combined effect.

THIS WEEK IN HISTORY

The Ides of March: The Conspiracy That Killed a Republic

Julius Caesar had crossed the Rubicon in 49 BC, won the civil war, and been appointed *dictator perpetuo* — dictator in perpetuity — in early 44 BC. He was days away from departing Rome on a campaign against the Parthians. The Senate meeting of March 15 was the last before he left.

The conspiracy was led by senators Marcus Junius Brutus and Gaius Cassius Longinus, with roughly 60 participants. They chose the Senate House deliberately — killing a tyrant before the full Senate would look like a noble act, not a political plot. In the days before, Caesar had been warned. A seer named Spurinna predicted his life was in danger no later than the Ides of March. On the morning of March 15, as Caesar passed the seer on the way to the Senate House, he called out playfully: "Well, the Ides of March have come!" The seer replied: "Aye, the Ides have come — but they are not yet gone."

Mark Antony was intercepted at the door and kept outside. Inside, the conspirators surrounded Caesar under the pretence of a petition. Casca struck first — a glancing blow to the neck. Caesar grabbed Casca's arm. Then it was all motion: Cassius slashed his face, others struck from every direction. Blinded by blood, Caesar fell against the pedestal of Pompey's statue. He was stabbed

23 times. Only the second wound — to the ribs — was fatal, according to what may be the earliest known autopsy report in history.

Brutus and his companions marched through Rome: "People of Rome, we are once again free!" They were met with silence. Citizens had locked their doors. Rather than restoring the Republic, the assassination triggered civil war. Caesar was posthumously deified. His great-nephew Octavian avenged the murder, hunted down the conspirators, and eventually became Augustus — the first Roman Emperor. The Republic they died to save never recovered. A conspiracy designed to preserve freedom that instead ended it — the gap between what we intend and what we cause.

Wikipedia · Britannica

ALSO THIS WEEK IN HISTORY

March 18, 1314 — Jacques de Molay, last Grand Master of the Knights Templar, was burned at the stake on an island in the Seine, before Notre Dame. From the flames, he reportedly cursed the King of France and Pope Clement V. Both were dead within the year. The House of Capet, which had ruled France for 300 years, was extinguished within fourteen.

March 21, 1804 — Napoleon promulgated the Napoleonic Code — the first modern legal framework to codify equality before the law, abolish hereditary nobility, and guarantee freedom of person and contract. He later considered it his greatest achievement. It remains the foundation of French law today.

March 20, 1815 — Napoleon entered Paris after escaping Elba, at the head of 140,000 regulars and 200,000 volunteers, beginning the Hundred Days. It lasted exactly 111 days, ending at Waterloo.

March 18, 1229 — Frederick II, Holy Roman Emperor, declared himself King of Jerusalem — not through battle, but through diplomacy. An excommunicated crusader king negotiated directly with Sultan Al-Kamil, reclaiming the holy city through paperwork. The Pope had excommunicated him before the crusade even left. The Patriarch of Jerusalem refused to crown him. He placed the crown on his own head.

ON THE RADAR — COMING UP

TONIGHT	**Juventus vs Sassuolo** — Serie A Matchday 30, 19:45 CET. Three points would take Juve to 56, one off fourth-placed Como.
26 MAR	**Super Mario Bros. Wonder Switch 2 Edition** — Bellabel Park co-op content. Also: Kena: Bridge of Spirits on Switch 2.
27 MAR	**007 First Light** — New James Bond game across all platforms including Switch 2. Built on the Hitman engine.

1 APR	**Artemis II launch window opens** — First crewed mission beyond LEO since 1972. Kennedy Space Center, 6:24 PM EDT.
6 APR	**Star Wars: Maul – Shadow Lord** — Two-episode Disney+ premiere. Watercolour noir animation.
7-8 APR	**Champions League Quarter-Final first legs** — Real Madrid vs Bayern, PSG vs Liverpool, Barça vs Atleti, Sporting vs Arsenal.
19 APR	**Arsenal vs Manchester City** — Premier League title showdown at the Etihad.
25 APR	**FM-84 new music** — First new material in years. Date confirmed via Instagram.
1 MAY	**Efteling: Hooghmoed opens** — New free-fall attraction next to Baron 1898. Families from 90cm tall.
22 MAY	**The Mandalorian & Grogu** — First Star Wars theatrical release since 2019. Cinemas and IMAX.
SAT	**NI Parkruns** — Bangor (County Down), Antrim, Comber, Stormont, Belfast Victoria, and dozens more. 9:30am every Saturday. Wear green for the St Patrick's weekend spirit.

The Signal.

A SUNDAY MORNING MAGAZINE · ISSUE #1 · MARCH 21, 2026

Created with Perplexity Computer